

We have been working on these projects for three to four years. Unlike most others where land acquisition begins after the project is announced, [here] land has been acquired, [and] environmental clearances taken. In many cases, the company has been formed. All master planning has been done... Cost estimates have been prepared. Everything is analysed and done through PM Gati Shakti and support from other ministries and states. Our target is to start construction of these greenfield cities within this fiscal... We have three years to complete construction. Companies will be expected to start production within three years of getting the land.

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Are you targeting any particular segment?

Though these are greenfield smart cities, there is an ecosystem around each location. For instance, in Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu, it is automobiles; in Greater Noida, it is white goods, electronics and mobile manufacturing, to name a few. The sectors have been identified based on market analysis, interest shown by investors, and the existing industrial ecosystem within 1,500 km. The master planning for infrastructure is done based on that. We will stick to this unless the investment and industrialisation game changes by the time it comes to selling and new sectors emerge. But it's not that other industries are a no go.

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How is the investor interest? Will it help India with the China+1 strategy?

Yes, not just us, but the whole government is working [so] that India should be a reliable,

sustainable destination for anybody coming from China or even otherwise. The whole world is seeing the trajectory on which the Indian economy has been for the past 10 years. At some point, we were lacking in infrastructure, but we have come a long way. We have improved in logistics. Of course, some things remain to be done, but that scope is always there.

The whole world is willing to bet on India. They just need locations where they can drop anchor. I hope, and I believe that foreign investors will drop anchor at these locations. As highlighted by the PM, states also need to work on policy... that is going to happen in the next four to five years, and with that, the ecosystem will improve further. You will see an immediate reflection of those changes in these cities.

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What about social infrastructure?

People find it difficult to move from one city to another; imagine asking someone to move from one city to a non-existent city... It takes time. We are trying to hasten that cycle by giving more jobs. We are not just providing plug-and-play, we are also providing walk to work with a holistic city life environment. I believe there are enough entrepreneurs in India that can populate these cities. We are talking of around 4 million direct and indirect jobs in these 12 cities. That translates to 4 million families and 20 million people. Of this, let's say even 10% start living in these cities, that makes 2 million, which is not a bad number. **BT**

in [attracting] companies to set up shop in these areas," he underlines, pointing to Dholera as another success story of the scheme.

"Not a lot of people are aware, but Dholera, the first semiconductor city of India, is also under NICDC," says Saini, adding that the response from investors has been more than satisfactory and this is likely to continue for other industrial smart cities. "At Dholera, the Tatas have already announced a semiconductor plant that they are in the process of constructing. The semiconductor ecosystem is coming to Dholera. The Micron plant, which is in Sanand, is also close to Dholera. The whole of government is working towards making Dholera the semiconductor destination in India," he says. Saini explains that this includes railways, which is constructing a rail link between Dholera and the western dedicated freight corridor; the NHAI which is constructing a greenfield expressway between Ahmedabad and Dholera; and obviously, the Gujarat government, which is investing a lot of money outside the project area to develop the social infrastructure, "to give water, power, transmission lines".

The four developed industrial smart cities are seen to have an investment potential of \$20.5 billion and have already locked in investments from companies including ReNew Power, Tata Electronics, Tata Chemicals, Torrent Power, Hyosung, Haier, Piramal and Kohler. Officials say there have been inquiries for the upcoming four projects as well.

Soon after the Cabinet approval, Vedanta Group Chairman Anil Agarwal had announced that the company would set up two industrial parks, one for aluminium and another for zinc and silver, on a not-for-profit basis. "For India, industrial parks are a good way to achieve